

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Malachi

Malachi

Malachi had several roles in his ministry. As a caring pastor, he reminded discouraged people that God loved them. As a wise teacher, he taught the people of Judah basic truths about God's character. As a strong prophet, he warned corrupt priests about God's judgment. As a spiritual guide, he called the people to sincere worship and urged them to live by the moral standards of God's covenant (a binding agreement). Malachi gives Israel a simple but important message from God: "I have loved you" (1:2).

Setting

Malachi wrote to Jews in the Persian province of Judea, probably during the rule of King Darius I of Persia (521–486 BC). Jewish exiles returning from Babylon had recently settled again in Judah. They joined those whom the Babylonians had not taken into exile.

When Malachi preached, the temple had been rebuilt, but it was much less impressive than Solomon's Temple. The priests and Levites held great influence in Judah, yet worship in the temple had become weak and careless. The priests led people into sin instead of guiding them toward God. Worshipers brought damaged or poor animals for sacrifice and failed to give the required tithes and offerings. The hopes announced earlier by the prophets Haggai and Zechariah also seemed to have faded. People no longer expected a new king from David's family through Zerubbabel.

Malachi spoke to people who had become cynical about religion, doubtful about politics, and spiritually discouraged. They expected:

- prosperity (Haggai 2:7, 18–19),
- a king from David's family line (Ezekiel 34:13, 23–24), and
- the new covenant promised through the prophet Jeremiah (Jeremiah 31:23, 31–34).

But they did not see these promises fulfilled. Many people believed that God had failed them.

Summary

Malachi explains who God is so that the people of Judah can better understand their covenant relationship with him. The book begins with Malachi's main message: God loves Israel (1:2–5). The prophet then develops this message through five more sections.

The second message (1:6–2:9) speaks mainly to the priests and Levites serving in the Second Temple (the temple rebuilt after the return from exile). The second message teaches that God is the Lord and Father of Israel and deserves true worship. The third message (2:10–16) applies God's love to human relationships, especially marriage. The fourth message (2:17–3:5) focuses on God's justice, calls people to honesty in speech and in business, and seeks genuine concern for people in need. The fifth message (3:6–12) emphasizes God's faithfulness and calls the people to faithful worship, especially through tithes and offerings. The final message (3:13–4:3) again calls Israel to honesty and faithfulness as they look toward the coming day of the Lord.

Malachi's care for the people appears throughout his preaching. He begins and ends his book with words of encouragement (1:2; 4:2).

Author

The book of Malachi does not directly explain who wrote it. However, most scholars believe that the prophet Malachi wrote down his own messages because 1:1 says, "This is the burden of the word of the LORD to Israel through Malachi." Nothing else is known about Malachi outside this book. The only personal detail given is that he was a prophet (1:1).

Date

Unlike many prophetic books, Malachi does not connect his message to the reign of a specific king (compare Zephaniah 1:1; Haggai 1:1; Zechariah 1:1). His language is similar to the language of Haggai and Zechariah, so he was probably a slightly later contemporary of those prophets.

Some scholars think the battle of Marathon between Persia and Greece, around 490 BC, may have influenced Malachi's message. Malachi may have viewed this conflict between East and West as a partial fulfillment of Haggai's prophecy that God would "shake the heavens and the earth" and "overturn royal thrones" (Haggai 2:21–22). Other scholars think Malachi may have written later in the 400s BC.

Literary Genre

Malachi's prophecies often follow the style of a legal dispute or courtroom argument. In this style, the speaker argues directly with the audience. Usually, the pattern includes:

1. The prophet states a truth.

2. The audience responds with a question or objection.
3. The prophet repeats and explains his main point.
4. The prophet gives more evidence to support it.

The goal is to remove every excuse for disagreement. This question-and-answer style later influenced the teaching methods used in Jewish rabbinic schools. A similar pattern also appears in the teaching of Jesus in Matthew 5:21-22, 27-28: “You have heard ... But I tell you ...”

Meaning and Message

Malachi calls people to follow God’s purposes faithfully. His preaching focuses on the covenant relationship between God and Israel and the responsibilities that come with that relationship.

Three of Malachi’s messages focus on right relationships. He teaches that a correct understanding of God helps people maintain healthy relationships. He speaks about marriage by condemning divorce and encouraging faithfulness between husband and wife. He also teaches about honesty and integrity in the wider community.

Malachi calls God’s people back to a true understanding of God as Israel’s Father, Master, and covenant God. He urges the people to worship rightly by offering temple sacrifices with sincerity. He also encourages faithful giving to God, who responds generously to those who trust and obey him.